

live.com from any web browser, you can only view your Xbox Live account information, not edit much of it. What this means to you is simple: If you're new to Xbox Live – maybe you've joined because of Windows Phone – and don't even have an Xbox 360 console, your account is going to look pretty weak.

One of the best reasons to join Xbox Live, and this is as true on Windows Phone as it was previously on the Xbox 360 console (and, to a lesser extent, on Windows PCs with Games for Windows - LIVE) is the games. Sure, Xbox Live offers some multimedia and social networking functionality on the console, but the real reason for this service is to get people together to compete against each other online. These online competitions take two general forms. That is, you can compete implicitly with your friends and others by trying to rack up higher overall Gamerscores, by completing single player games, and single player achievements, before others do, and so on. You can also compete explicitly with others via online multi-player games. On the Xbox 360, the most common of these games are online shooters, such as those in the *Call of Duty*, *Gears of War* and *Halo* series. But there are many other wildly popular online game types on Xbox Live as well.

If you're at all competitive, you'll immediately be drawn to Xbox Live's achievements system. On the Xbox 360 console, each game is generally given up to 1,000 achievement points to dole out, typically via any number of individual achievements. When you do trigger an achievement perhaps by completing an in-game level or other task, the console pops up the ever-popular Achievement Unlocked message, which provides the name of the achievement. You can tap a button on the Xbox 360 console to learn more, including how many achievement points you've earned and the description of the achievement. You can also view your overall Gamerscore to see how the achievement points affected things.

The Games Hub

On Windows Phone, the Games Hub is the centre for all of your on-device gaming activities and the place you'll visit to play games, examine your Xbox Live profile and achievements, view and send game invites, buy and try new games, learn more about new games and gaming-related events and more. The Games Hub is representative of the panoramic experiences in Windows Phone, offering a sweeping, multi-screen interface that pans from left to right.

There are four basic sections, or columns, in the Games Hub: Collection, Spotlight, Xbox Live and Requests. We'll examine each of these now,